GRANDFATHER PARADOX

Written by

Kerry Ann Burke

Copyright (c) 2025-2026

SECOND DRAFT (Oct. 2026)

kerry.ann.boyko.screenwriter@gmail.com

INT. COFFEESHOP — DAY

DAVID (30s), unshaven, exhausted, wearing a ragged, grubby sweatshirt, sits alone at a small table, nervously checking a smartwatch. The timer is a countdown clock, with about 8 minutes on it. He sips a cup of coffee.

DAVID
Should be soon.

The door opens.

SFX: SHOP BELL.

INDIGO (30s) enters. She has a healed scar running from her temple into her hairline. She's wearing a hoodie and jeans, also grubby. Patched in places. Hand-stitched repairs. On her hoodie: "TEMPLE UNIVERSITY CLASS OF 2087".

She walks straight to David's table, sitting without invitation, then speaks directly to David with urgency.

INDIGO
David. I know why you're here. I know what you're about to do. I need to stop you.

David stares, and hesitates before answering.

DAVID
You couldn’t possibly. Who are you?

INDIGO
A time traveller. Like you. But from further in the future. 2095.

David scans the room, suspicious. Then he turns back to Indigo.

DAVID
Surprised there’s still people in 2095. You some kind of time cop? Come to prevent paradoxes or ensure the proper flow of history or something?

INDIGO
No. Listen--this will come as a shock, but I built your time machine. Well. Rebuilt it.

DAVID
How’d you get my machine?

INDIGO
You left it to me. After you died.

He raises an eyebrow, amused.

DAVID
What are you, my daughter?

INDIGO
(dead serious)
Yes.

A moment of shock. Then he scoffs.

DAVID
Yeah, right. I'd never be cruel enough to bring a child into a world this broken.

INDIGO
I don't know what to tell you. You meet Mum sometime in the early 2060s. Things happen, I guess. I tell you more, I might do by accident what you came here to do on purpose.

DAVID
Things happen. Yeah. Genocides. They happen. Wars. Authoritarians win. And let me guess, future lady -- they keep winning in your time too.

INDIGO
You don't know that.

DAVID
But you do, don't you? Tell me I'm wrong.

She looks away.

DAVID (cont'd)
Thought so.

David swigs his coffee.

DAVID (cont'd)
I should have gone back to the 1940s. Tell Orwell he was an optimist.

He looks at his smartwatch.

DAVID (cont'd)
Alright. I've got a couple of minutes. Tell me about the future. Tell me what's so great about it.

INDIGO
I can't. You know I can't.

DAVID
I'm not asking for lottery numbers or the next ten presidents here. Don't give me specifics, then. You say you're my daughter. It's possible. But are you healthy? Safe? Happy?

She frowns.

INDIGO
I'm alive. I'm surviving. You taught me how. You taught me how to survive everything.

DAVID
I guess I would've. I'd owe you that much.

INDIGO
So help me. Help me survive *now*.

David sighs. Serious consideration.

DAVID
I... no, that... survival isn't a lesson you should have to teach a kid.
(pause)
I believe you, you know. Can't think of a reason you'd lie to me. But you have to see... doing this... this way, you'll never have needed to learn it in the first place.

INDIGO
Because I'll never have existed.

DAVID
I guess not.

David stops, sincerely thinking about that. He drums his fingers on the counter.

But then he shakes his head.

DAVID (cont'd)
But... I'm sorry. Not just for what I'm about to do, but what I uh... did. Or will have done. I didn't think I could hate myself more, now you're telling me I brought a kid into a doomed world.

INDIGO
It's not... *doomed* doomed.

DAVID
(sarcastic)
That's reassuring.
(softly)
Point is, bringing you into this world must have caused you so much pain. Let me fix it.

INDIGO
This doesn’t fix anything. It just *ends* it.

DAVID
Sometimes that *is* mercy. When something’s broken beyond repair...

Indigo grabs David's hand, looking in his eyes, pleading.

INDIGO
It has *joy*. Even broken lives have joy.

David looks away, breaking eye contact.

DAVID
They're just... moments. Against a lifetime of pain. And those tiny moments of joy... just make the pain that much crueler.

INDIGO
You don’t know that's what it'll be like for me.

DAVID
I wasn’t talking about your life. I meant mine.
(beat)
I've wanted to die since I was twelve years old. But I kept telling myself, “It’ll get better.”
(beat)
It didn’t.
(beat)
Then I told myself, “Well, if I made it this far, I can’t quit now.”
(beat)
Sunk-cost fallacy.

David closes his eyes. Leans against the back wall.

DAVID (cont'd)
(quiet)
I thought about going back to kill myself at twelve. But this... this seemed cleaner. More likely to work. Less disruptive.

INDIGO
I think it's pretty damn disruptive.

DAVID
In a few moments, neither of us will think anything at all.

INDIGO
(scared)
David. What you're doing is going to kill me.

DAVID
Not kill. Erasing. This is a mercy.

David's face hardens as he says it.

Indigo winces, frustration turning to restrained anger.

DAVID (cont'd)
Don’t take this the wrong way, but I *don’t* want to see you grow up. I don’t want to tie your shoes or teach you to ride a bike. Because if I do, *it’ll break me* to know what’s coming. To see you suffer through what I did.

INDIGO
How do you *know* the world gets worse?

DAVID
Because if it *didn’t*... you would’ve led with that.

Silence. Indigo looks away. She blinks back a tear.

INDIGO
Don’t you want to know my name?

DAVID
If it’s all the same, no.

INDIGO
It’s Indigo.

He pauses. Briefly.

DAVID
Beautiful name. Your mother must’ve picked it.

Indigo almost smiles, but her voice trembles.

INDIGO
No. You did.
(beat)
I’m scared.

DAVID
You don’t have to be. Not anymore.
Neither of us do.

David's smartwatch lets out a little BEEP. He looks at it. then looks to the door.

The bell above the door JINGLES.

JOHN (20s) enters. He's got slightly shaggy hair.

David closes his eyes for half a second, bracing.

David gets up. Indigo gets up immediately after, tries to physically hold him back.

INDIGO
Don't do this, please.

David shakes her off.

DAVID
You John Walters?

John is disturbed by the scene.

JOHN
Yeah.

David gets out a hundred dollar bill from his jeans pocket. Indigo goes to grab it out of his hand, but David jerks it away.

DAVID
You need a haircut. Go get one.
Right now.

David holds up the money.

JOHN
Now?

DAVID
Now.

David places the bill in John's hand.

INDIGO
(sudden)
No. John... you should stay.

JOHN
This is getting weird.

DAVID
Then let me simplify it. A strange man you don't know is giving you a hundred dollars to leave a place. You could take the cash and leave. Or you could start asking the strange and possibly dangerous man a lot of piercing questions about what his business is.
(beat)
Which seems like the smarter play to you?

A pause.

JOHN
Goodbye.

John exits.

SFX: SHOP BELL

SFX: BLIP.

David looks back, the camera pans to follow his gaze-- Indigo is gone.

SFX: BLIP.

The camera pans back. So is David.

SFX: SHOP BELL

VIOLET (20s) enters, orders coffee, and sits with a book: H.G. Wells' *The Time Machine*.

She reads.

FADE TO BLACK:

(Just as credits start to roll, we cut back in-- it's a fakeout.)

SFX: SHOP BELL

SMASH IN:

JOHN returns, confused, empty-handed.

JOHN
Excuse me--miss? Did you see a man? Tall, 30s. Kinda dangerous-seeming? Looked like he hated being alive.
(MORE)

JOHN (cont'd)
(beat)
He gave me a hundred dollars to get a haircut, and then... it vanished with a little "blip" noise. While I was holding it.

He holds up his hands. Empty.

She looks up.

VIOLET
Why would someone do that?

JOHN
Beats me. I *had* it. Right in my hand.

He holds up his hand again.

SFX: BLIP

Now there's a hundred dollar bill in it.

He stares at it. She does too.

VIOLET
That's not nothing.
(beat)
Okay, that's a neat trick. How'd you do that?

JOHN
(stammering)
I-- I didn't.

VIOLET
(shrugging, teasing)
Whatever pickup line this is? It's working. I'm Violet.

She extends a hand.

John finds his bearings and shakes it.

JOHN
John. John Walters. Friends call me Jack.

VIOLET
Well, Jack--your mystery man was right. You could use a haircut. Not bad. Just a little shaggy.

JOHN
I guess I did say I would...

VIOLET
What're you doing with the change?

He pauses. Then smiles.

JOHN
Got any plans Saturday night?

Violet motions to the empty seat at her table.

INT. COFFEESHOP — FAR TABLE - DAY

We pan over back to David and Indigo's table, where now they're both sitting there, watching. David's furrowing his brow, trying to make sense of it.

DAVID
Wait. Wait.

David gestures with his finger, trying to trace the chain of logic.

DAVID (cont'd)
I don't exist. So I never give him the money. So he comes back to... and then he meets...

He looks at John and Violet. Then to Indigo.

Indigo smirks.

INDIGO
Congratulations. You just wingmanned grandpa into a meet cute with grandma.

DAVID
Oh, you've got to be kidding me.

David hangs his head.

DAVID (cont'd)
The universe wants me to suffer.

INDIGO
Maybe. I don't really know how bad it's been for you up to this point. And I can't promise that it gets better. But I can promise... it's not all bad.

Indigo looks at her smartwatch, and starts to tear up.

INDIGO (cont'd)
I've only got another minute before auto-return. How about you?

He checks his watch.

DAVID
Same.
(beat)
You said I'm dead in your time.

INDIGO
Yeah. In a weird way... it's nice to see you again.

DAVID
I don't know what to say.
(pause)
What's the one thing that every girl wants to hear from her father?

INDIGO
That you're proud of me and that I'm pretty.

DAVID
I'll make a note of that.

Indigo laughs through her tears.

INDIGO
I know. You told me all the time growing up.

David takes that in.

INDIGO (cont'd)
And I'm glad I got to see you again.
(beat)
You were a *very good dad*.

DAVID
Find that hard to believe.

INDIGO
You were. You were a broken father. A sad father. But you were still a *good father*.

He smiles. Sadly.

SFX: BLIP

He disappears.

SFX: BLIP

She disappears.

Over at the other booth, John and Violet leave the shop together.

CUT TO BLACK:

THE END